Pakistan: ‘Behind us was a large circular mound, or eminence, and to the west was an irregular rocky height, crowned with the remains of buildings, in fragments of walls, with niches, after the eastern manner … Tradition affirms the existence here of a city … destroyed by a particular visitation of Providence, brought down by the lust and crimes of the sovereign.’[2]

Half a century later, when General Alexander Cunningham, founding father of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), came to examine the mound at Harappa he found it devastated by contractors who had used its bricks to lay the track for the Lahore–Multan railway line. He moved on, believing that there was little left to find. But he later got his hands on a ‘most curious seal’ from that same site (see illustration above), engraved with the figure of a bull, above which was ‘an inscription in six characters, which are quite unknown to me. They are certainly not Indian letters … I conclude that the seal is foreign to India.’

Cunningham was wrong, but never lived to see *how* wrong. Another half century passed before the moment when the archaeologist Rakaldas Banerji, while excavating a two-thousand-year-old Buddhist stupa on the summit of a large mound known locally as Mohenjo-Daro, or ‘hill of the dead men’, in Sind west of the Indus River, realised that its foundations rested on the bricks of much older and far more extensive buildings.[3] The then director of the ASI, Sir John Marshall, came to see for himself, and what he saw there led to the first chapter of India’s history having to be totally rewritten. ‘Hitherto India had been almost universally regarded as one of the younger countries of the world. No monuments were known to exist of an earlier date than the third century BC,’ wrote Marshall.

> Now, at a single bound, we have taken back our knowledge of Indian civilisation some 3,000 years earlier and have established the fact that in the third